

gRPC and gRPC-Web

gRPC is Google's remote procedure call protocol. Over the years, there were many RPC protocols. I still remember the days of CORBA and DCOM, and Java RMI. Fast-forward to the modern web, where REST beat SOAP to become the big gorilla in the arena of web APIs. But, these days, gRPC is beating REST. gRPC provides a contract-based model with strong typing, efficient payload based on protobuf, and is automatically generating client code. The combination is very powerful. The last refuge of REST was its ubiquity and the ease of calling REST APIs bearing JSON payloads from web applications running in the browser.

But, even this advantage is fading away. You could always put a REST-compatible gRPC gateway in front of your gRPC service, but I consider it a kludge. On the other hand, gRPC-web is a full-fledged JavaScript library that lets web applications simply invoke gRPC services. See <https://github.com/grpc/grpc-web/tree/master/packages/grpc-web>.

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